

ANCIENT HISTORY — PART 4

THE 16 MAHAJANAPADAS & RISE OF THE MAGADHA EMPIRE

16 Mahajanapadas

Why Magadha Rose

Haryanka Dynasty

Shishunaga

Nanda Dynasty

Alexander's Invasion

Part 4 / 7 — Ancient History Series — SSC CGL / CHSL / CPO / MTS-GD

CGL READY PROMISE

Full lecture + notes content on the Mahajanapadas and the Magadha Empire, with every PYQ-verified gap fact woven directly into its relevant topic below — no separate "extra facts" section.

1. From Jana to Mahajanapada

Stage	Meaning
Jana	Tribe (Aryan clans, e.g. Bharata, Puru, Kuru)
Janapada	Land/territory where a Jana settled — "foothold of a tribe"
Mahajanapada	Consolidation of smaller Janapadas into large territorial states, by c. 600 BC

2. Sources for the Mahajanapadas

Source	Detail
Ashtadhyayi (Panini)	Sanskrit grammar text; mentions a total of 40 Janapadas
Anguttara Nikaya (Buddhist)	Mentions 16 Mahajanapadas — the standard number used in exams
Digha Nikaya (Buddhist)	Mentions only 12 Mahajanapadas
Bhagavati Sutra (Jain)	Also lists Mahajanapadas, with some variation from the Buddhist lists

DIRECT PYQ

"How many Mahajanapadas are listed in Buddhist and Jain texts?" → **16** (per Anguttara Nikaya — the figure tested by default unless a question specifically names Digha Nikaya, in which case the answer is 12).

3. The 16 Mahajanapadas — Capital & Location Table

#	Mahajanapada	Capital	Modern location
1	Anga	Champa	Munger & Bhagalpur, Bihar
2	Magadha	Rajagriha (later Pataliputra)	Gaya & Patna, Bihar
3	Kashi	Varanasi (from Varuna + Assi rivers)	Banaras, UP
4	Vatsa	Kaushambi	Allahabad, UP
5	Kosala	Shravasti / Ayodhya	Eastern UP (Gonda, Bahraich)
6	Surasena	Mathura	Mathura, UP
7	Panchala	Ahichchhatra & Kampilya	Western UP (Bareilly)
8	Kuru	Indraprastha	Meerut & SE Haryana
9	Matsya	Viratnagar	Jaipur, Rajasthan (Shipra river nearby)
10	Chedi/Chetiya	Sothivati/Banda	Bundelkhand
11	Avanti	Ujjain / Mahishmati	Madhya Pradesh & Malwa
12	Gandhara	Taxila	Rawalpindi (Pakistan)
13	Kamboja	Poonch/Rajapura	Rajori & Hajra, Kashmir
14	Asmaka/Assaka	Pratishthan/Paithan	Bank of Godavari — the only Mahajanapada located south of the Vindhyas
15	Vajji	Vaishali	Vaishali, Bihar
16	Malla	Kushinara	Deoria, UP

SUB-CLAN FACTS

Vajji was a confederacy of 8 clans, including the **Jnatrika**, **Videha** and **Lichchhavi**. Vaishali (Vajji's capital) is remembered as a leading centre of early republican/ganasangha government.

GOVERNANCE TYPE

The 16 Mahajanapadas were either **Monarchies** (hereditary king, multiple e.g. Magadha, Kosala, Avanti) or **Republics/Ganasanghas** (multiple decision-makers, e.g. Vajji, Malla). Kuru, Kamboja, Vajji, Malla and Assaka are frequently cited examples where clan-based/republican elements existed.

4. Why Magadha Became Supreme

Reason	Detail
Strategic geography	Located south of the Ganga, at the confluence of the Ganga and Son rivers ("Doab"-like advantage) — fertile land for agriculture
Mineral wealth	Proximity to the Chota Nagpur Plateau region gave access to iron ore and other minerals
Military resources	Large numbers of war elephants available
Defensible capital	Rajagriha (Rajgir) was surrounded by 5 hills, giving natural fortification; Pataliputra later sat at the Ganga-Son confluence
Standing army	Magadha, especially under the Nandas, is credited as the first Mahajanapada to maintain a large, centrally-paid standing army
Leadership	A sequence of capable, expansionist rulers across dynasties

5. Dynasties of Magadha — Overview

Sequence: **Haryanka → Shishunaga → Nanda → Maurya** (Maurya covered separately in Part 6).

Haryanka Dynasty

Ruler	Detail
Bimbisara (c. 544/543–492 BC)	First major/important ruler of Magadha; also known as Seniya/Shrenika in Buddhist and Jain tradition; conquered Anga, taking the title after capturing its capital Champa; formed marriage alliances — Kaushal Devi (sister of King Prasenjit of Kosala), Chellana (a Lichchhavi princess), and a Madra-clan princess; sent his physician Jivaka to treat the king of Avanti (Ujjain) suffering from jaundice; patron of Buddha; patronised the First Buddhist Council ; contemporary of both Buddha and Mahavira
Ajatashatru (492–460 BC)	Son of Bimbisara and Chellana; imprisoned/killed his father to seize the throne — hence called Kunik (Pitruhanta, "father-killer") in tradition; conquered the Lichchhavis and Vaishali (Vajji confederacy) using war engines/catapults; defeated Kosala and married the Kosalan king's daughter; patronised the First Buddhist Council (per some traditions)
Udayin (c. 460–444 BC)	Son of Ajatashatru; shifted the capital from Rajagriha to Pataliputra , founded at the confluence of the Ganga and Son rivers

Shishunaga Dynasty

Ruler/Fact	Detail
Shishunaga	Founder; defeated Avanti (capital Ujjain) and merged it into Magadha, ending a long-standing rival power
Kalashoka/Kakavarna	Son and successor of Shishunaga; patronised the Second Buddhist Council at Vaishali, held 100 years after Buddha's Mahaparinirvana

Nanda Dynasty

Ruler	Detail
Mahapadma Nanda	Founder; took the title "Ekkrat" (sole/universal sovereign, "empire builder"); also called Ugrasena and, in some sources, "Aparoparashurama" ; described in the Puranas as "destroyer of all Kshatriyas" after defeating rivals like the Kurus, Kalingas and Kashis; built the largest and wealthiest Indian empire up to that time, with a very large standing army
Nanda army scale	Greek writers (Diodorus, Curtius Rufus) record roughly 2,00,000 infantry, 20,000 cavalry, 3,000 elephants
Dhana Nanda	Last ruler of the Nanda dynasty; Alexander invaded India during his reign; dethroned by Chandragupta Maurya (with Chanakya/Kautilya's help), founding the Mauryan Empire

6. Alexander's Invasion — Quick Facts

Fact	Detail
Battle of Hydaspes (Jhelum)	326 BC; Alexander vs Porus (local ruler); Jhelum's Vedic name was Vitasta , Greek name Hydaspes
Outcome	Alexander returned Porus's territory to him after victory; left commander Seleucus Nicator in the region, who later founded the Seleucid Empire and was defeated by Chandragupta Maurya
Alexander's death	323 BC, in Babylon

7. CGL Master Revision — Learn These First

Trigger	Answer
Number of Mahajanapadas (standard)	16 (Anguttara Nikaya)
Digha Nikaya count	12

Ashtadhyayi author & Janapada count	Panini; mentions 40 Janapadas
Mahajanapada south of the Vindhyas	Assaka/Asmaka
Capital of Magadha before Pataliputra	Rajagriha
Founder of Pataliputra	Udayin
Vajji confederacy clans	Jnatrika, Videha, Lichchhavi (8 clans total)
First important ruler of Magadha	Bimbisara
Bimbisara's other name	Seniya/Shrenika
Bimbisara's physician	Jivaka
Ajatashatru's dynasty	Haryanka
Ajatashatru also called	Kunik (Pitruhanta)
Ruler who shifted capital Rajagriha → Pataliputra	Udayin
Dynasty that defeated Avanti	Shishunaga
Patron of Second Buddhist Council	Kalashoka
Founder of Nanda dynasty	Mahapadma Nanda
Mahapadma Nanda's titles	Ekrat; Ugrasena; "Aparoparashurama"
Last Nanda ruler	Dhana Nanda
Nanda army size (Greek estimate)	2,00,000 infantry, 20,000 cavalry, 3,000 elephants
Who defeated Dhana Nanda	Chandragupta Maurya, with Chanakya's help
Battle of Hydaspes year	326 BC
Jhelum's Vedic / Greek names	Vitasta / Hydaspes
Alexander's death — year & place	323 BC, Babylon
Seleucus Nicator	Alexander's commander left in the region; later defeated by Chandragupta Maurya

8. PYQ-Style Question Bank

- Q1.** How many Mahajanapadas are listed in Buddhist texts (Anguttara Nikaya)? **Ans:** 16.
- Q2.** How many Mahajanapadas does the Digha Nikaya mention? **Ans:** 12.
- Q3.** Which text mentions 40 Janapadas, and who wrote it? **Ans:** Ashtadhyayi, by Panini.
- Q4.** Which Mahajanapada was located south of the Vindhyas? **Ans:** Assaka/Asmaka.
- Q5.** What was the capital of Magadha before Pataliputra? **Ans:** Rajagriha.
- Q6.** Who founded Pataliputra, and where? **Ans:** Udayin, at the confluence of the Ganga and Son rivers.
- Q7.** Name the 8 clans of the Vajji confederacy (key ones). **Ans:** Jnatrika, Videha, Lichchhavi (among others).
- Q8.** Who was the first important ruler of the Magadhan Empire? **Ans:** Bimbisara.
- Q9.** By what other name is Bimbisara known? **Ans:** Seniya/Shrenika.
- Q10.** Who was Bimbisara's physician, sent to treat the king of Avanti? **Ans:** Jivaka.
- Q11.** What dynasty did Ajatashatru belong to? **Ans:** Haryanka.
- Q12.** By what title is Ajatashatru also known, referencing his patricide? **Ans:** Kunik (Pitruhanta).
- Q13.** Which ruler shifted the Magadhan capital from Rajagriha to Pataliputra? **Ans:** Udayin.
- Q14.** Which dynasty defeated and annexed Avanti into Magadha? **Ans:** Shishunaga dynasty.
- Q15.** Who patronised the Second Buddhist Council at Vaishali? **Ans:** Kalashoka.
- Q16.** Who founded the Nanda dynasty? **Ans:** Mahapadma Nanda.
- Q17.** What titles did Mahapadma Nanda hold? **Ans:** Ekrat; Ugrasena; "Aparoparashurama."
- Q18.** Who was the last ruler of the Nanda dynasty? **Ans:** Dhana Nanda.
- Q19.** According to Greek writers, what was the approximate size of the Nanda army? **Ans:** 2,00,000 infantry, 20,000 cavalry, 3,000 elephants.
- Q20.** Who defeated Dhana Nanda to found the Mauryan Empire? **Ans:** Chandragupta Maurya, aided by Chanakya (Kautilya).
- Q21.** In which year was the Battle of Hydaspes fought, and between whom? **Ans:** 326 BC; Alexander vs Porus.
- Q22.** What was the Vedic name of the river Jhelum? **Ans:** Vitasta (Greek: Hydaspes).
- Q23.** When and where did Alexander die? **Ans:** 323 BC, in Babylon.
- Q24.** Who was the Greek commander left behind by Alexander, later defeated by Chandragupta Maurya? **Ans:** Seleucus Nicator.

9. Last-Minute One-Page Revision

THE ENTIRE PART IN ONE FLOW

VEDIC JANA → JANAPADA → 16 MAHAJANAPADAS (Anguttara Nikaya) → MAGADHA rises (geography + minerals + army + capable rulers) → HARYANKA (Bimbisara → Ajatashatru → Udayin founds Pataliputra) → SHISHUNAGA (defeats Avanti; Kalashoka patronises 2nd Buddhist Council) → NANDA (Mahapadma Nanda's huge empire/army → Dhana Nanda) → ALEXANDER'S INVASION (326 BC, Hydaspes, dies 323 BC Babylon) → CHANDRAGUPTA MAURYA defeats Dhana Nanda → feeds directly into the Mauryan Empire (Part 6).